way for the army through Sindh. ‘Twenty thousand men are now under orders to do what a word might have done earlier,’ he wrote to Holland, ‘and two millions of money must be sunk in to do what I offered to do for two lakhs!’[132] But he was not unhappy: his orders had come in an envelope inscribed ‘Sir Alexander Burnes’. At first he thought it was an error; only on opening it did he discover he had been given a knighthood. His mission may have failed, and Macnaghten may have been given the political command of the expedition he had hoped for; but his willingness publicly to support a policy he had always opposed, against a ruler he had liked and whose hospitality he had enjoyed, had been noted by his superiors. So had the fact that he had kept quiet when his despatches from Kabul were edited in such a way that made it appear he had always supported the restoration of Shuja before being published as a Parliamentary Blue Book.[n] For all the frustrations of the last few months, he had kept his mouth shut and been rewarded for his silence. His star was still in the ascendant.

On 1 October, Auckland issued what came to be known as the Simla Manifesto, formally declaring war and announcing Britain’s intention to restore Shah Shuja to the Afghan throne by force. ‘Poor, dear peaceful George has gone to war,’ wrote Emily to her uncle, the former Governor General Lord Minto, who had first despatched Elphinstone to Afghanistan. ‘Rather an inconsistency in his character.’[133]

Auckland’s manifesto was more or less pure propaganda – a deliberate and blatant inversion of the available intelligence – and was recognised at once by the Indian press as ‘a most disingenuous distortion of the truth’.[134] One Indian civil servant pointed out that the manifesto used ‘the words “justice” and “necessity”, and the terms “frontier”, “security of the possessions of the British Crown” and “national defence” in a manner for which fortunately no precedent existed in the English language’.[135]

In the manifesto Auckland accused Dost Mohammad of ‘urging the most unreasonable pretensions, avowing schemes of aggrandizement and ambition injurious to the security and peace of the frontiers of India’ in pursuit of which ‘he openly threatened . . . to call in every foreign aid which he could command’, and of having ‘made a sudden and unprovoked attack on our ancient ally, Maharajah Ranjit Singh’. He was also accused of giving ‘undisguised support to Persian designs . . . of extending Persian influence and authority to the banks of, and even beyond, the Indus’. The war, he claimed, was intended ‘to set up a permanent barrier against schemes of